



IS THERE A GOOD CASE FOR NEW ZEALAND EXCEPTIONALISM?

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ABSTRACT The upsurge in cultural nationalism in New Zealand has failed to produce a good case that New Zealand is an exceptional society. The reason for this is that New Zealand has not had a chance to develop a culture that is autochthonous in significant respects. New Zealand's domination by the cultures of Britain, Australia and America in the 19th and 20th centuries prevented its history from taking a significantly different path. The lack of autochthony is attributed to the structural effects of physical isolation. Remoteness made its human history unusually short, led it to be exceptionally exposed to the global revolution in transport and communication from the mid-19th century, and severely constrained its population size.

KEYWORDS autochthony • culture • exceptionalism • isolation • New Zealand

Despite the growth in cultural nationalism and the preoccupation with New Zealand's identity over the last two decades, no-one has yet advanced a good case that New Zealand's history diverged in significant respects from that of other comparable societies. This absence of debate about the country's exceptionalism stands in marked contrast to the situation in other historiographies. Historians of early modern Britain have discussed whether Britain was an *Ancien Regime* society like the rest of Europe (Black, 1992). A key issue in the historiography of modern Germany is whether Germany diverged from the rest of Western Europe in having far weaker traditions of liberalism and democracy (the *Sonderweg* thesis) (Evans, 1997). American historians have engaged in a wide-ranging debate about American exceptionalism ever since Werner Sombart's 1906 classic, *Why Is There no Socialism in the United States?*, claimed that America's extraordinarily abundant opportunities for

upward social mobility made it one of the few western democracies where a socialist party has never come to power (Lipset, 1996).

There were, of course, multitudinous events in New Zealand's past that did not happen elsewhere. But these in themselves do not indicate that New Zealand had an exceptionalist history that is composed of many events that are both unique or highly unusual and significant. Every country has umpteen events in its past which are unique but most of these are insignificant. What constitutes a unique or unusual event that is also of historical significance is one that is capable of being composed into a theory about the society that explains or unifies many important phenomena. To be regarded as exceptional, a country's history must not only experience a unique or unusual event but also take a divergent path from that of others in consequence.

Many significant phenomena that are considered to have made New Zealand's history different are, on close inspection, not different at all. A prime example is the reforms of the Liberal era. It is often taken for granted that these were unique to New Zealand, conferring upon it the special identity as the 'social laboratory' of the world. In fact some of the Australian colonies and states at around the same time passed similar experimental legislation and also possessed this self-image (Castles, 1999; Denoon et al., 2000), a point William Pember Reeves indirectly recognized by naming his famous book *State Experiments in Australia and New Zealand* (1902).

Another significant New Zealand trait that is commonly but mistakenly identified as peculiar to New Zealand is the idea of 'man alone' (e.g. Sinclair, 1998: 337–8). As originally depicted in John Mulgan's famous novel in 1939 and in Frank Sargeson's short stories, man alone is a working-class itinerant, lacking in artifice, a rebel against oppressive middle-class conventions and authority, resourceful, adaptable, practical, single, laconic, loyal to his mates, individualistic, a rural dweller, and a master of rural skills and of survival. The myth of man alone, however, is not a New Zealand invention. Australians created an identical hero at a much earlier date, in the late 19th century, during the upsurge of Australian cultural nationalism (Phillips, 1983; Ward, 1977).

Spurious as well is the notion widely-held by fiction writers in the middle decades of the 20th century that New Zealand was blighted by a particularly virulent form of Puritanism. Australian intellectuals also complained bitterly about the 'wowsers' of their society, as did inter-war American writers like H. L. Mencken (Mencken, 1965, 1991; Dunstan, 1968; Jones, 2003).

There are other major events and traits that might be more capable of being constructed into an exceptionalist case.¹ But the list of possible candidates is hardly long, and it remains to be seen whether any is capable of being developed into a full-scale and plausible argument, let alone one having the unifying and explanatory power of the *Sonderweg* thesis or Sombart's thesis.

I

In 1945 Gordon Mirams, the *New Zealand Listener's* film reviewer, published the first serious account of movie culture in New Zealand (Shelton, 2003). Now undeservedly neglected, but remarkably advanced for its time for it anticipated much of what would later be called cultural studies, his book, *Speaking Candidly*, made two arresting observations that are central to my claim.

The first was that 'If ever a national post-mortem is performed on us, I think they will find there are three words written on New Zealand's heart – ANZAC, HOLLYWOOD, and HOME', to which he added the revealing comment, 'But only a very rash prophet would venture to suggest which word will be carved the deepest'. Mirams' observation, in other words, was that New Zealand culture was a pastiche of four elements: the Australian, the New Zealand, the American and the British, with the imported by implication possessing overall dominance, but with some uncertainty about which of the imported elements might be the principal one (Mirams, 1945: 125).

Mirams failed to indicate what the New Zealand content of the pastiche was. But he was quite clear about what accounted for the predominance of the British, American and Australian elements: New Zealanders were heavy consumers of radio programmes and movies and these programmes and movies were predominantly British, Australian and American imports. The national radio stations had a BBC style, the commercial an American (Mirams, 1945: 125). Only one local newsreel service operated in New Zealand as opposed to five American and two Australian. The 736,000 New Zealanders who patronized the movies on average each week would not have watched a New Zealand feature film, and though they might have seen a British production it was far more likely it would have been from Hollywood. As a consequence, the leading actors regarded as stars by New Zealanders were all from Hollywood (Mirams, 1945: 25). Through Hollywood, New Zealanders had acquired a good though distorted general knowledge of America, a better one than British movies conveyed about Britain. Indeed, four decades of intense exposure to American cinema had led New Zealanders to become more Americanized than most realized and would care to admit. American visitors 'found us to be a people pretty much like themselves' (Mirams, 1945: 123).

What Mirams might also have pointed out was that the Americanization of New Zealand culture in the first two-thirds or so of the 20th century was manifested in other ways, though the influence was not transmitted by Hollywood but by print and travel. The dominant architectural styles in the first half of the 20th century were borrowed from American pattern books and architectural magazines (Toomath, 1996). The ideology of first-wave New Zealand feminism in the late 19th century came from the United States, as did most of the ideational impetus behind second-wave feminism from the late 1960s. Between the 1920s and the 1940s, America was the key source

of progressive educational ideas and had a major influence on social thought, with something like 30 leading public intellectuals visiting America on Carnegie Corporation grants (Carter, 1993: 158–62). American programmes were highly popular from the time they first featured in radio broadcasts in 1931 (Day, 1994: 124–5), and they were the principal fare on television from its establishment in 1960 (Wood, 2005). The stationing of over 100,000 Americans in New Zealand during the Second World War had a marked effect on the sexual mores of women, the entertainment industry, and consumer tastes and expectations (Ebbett, 1984; Taylor, 1986: 628ff, 1023ff, 1848ff). In four of the five major turning points in modern New Zealand political history, the popular ideologies that helped to transform electoral allegiances and produce major shifts in power originated from North America.²

The notion that New Zealand culture was a pastiche dominated by imported elements also permeates the early novels of Ronald Hugh Morrieson (1922–72). Having no connection with the New Zealand literary scene, but with a natural talent for black comedy and a burning ambition to be a writer, and living with his mum in his native Taranaki all his life where he was a staunch member of the local booze culture, Morrieson was a genuine oddity who became New Zealand literature's most acute and authentic commentator of provincial Kiwidad.³ All three of his melodramatic black comedies (1963, 1964, 1974) are set in New Zealand's small provincial towns in the mid-20th century, and it is noteworthy that the most salient characteristics of these places and their people are not New Zealand-specific but a mix of the New Zealand, American, Australian, and English. The fantasies of some of the characters are taken from Hollywood movies, they use American cars for conspicuous display, their manners are often English lower-middle class, and the slang and much else are Australian, Australasian and American. Interestingly, Morrieson had a following in Australia before acquiring one in New Zealand, perhaps indicating that, contrary to what Mirams implied, the principal imported element in the pastiche was Australian.⁴

The pastiche also left a deep imprint on the early stories of Frank Sargeson, another marginal man and remarkable social observer of the New Zealand underclass. Sargeson's claim to fame is his creation of a genre of short story writing where the interior monologue conveys the manner of speaking and thought of the itinerant male working class with whom Sargeson had an unusually close association. In 1940 the critic Eric McCormick noted Sargeson's mastery of the

distinctive New Zealand idiom which is different from the popular speech of the Australian or the Englishman or the American, though it contains elements derived from each of these sources. . . . [Sargeson] is the exponent of a local tradition that has hitherto been inarticulate. (McCormick cited in King, 1995: 201–2)

The second observation Mirams made was that although New Zealanders were able to communicate what their country was like in material and

physical terms, they had failed to communicate what they were like as a people. He based this generalization on a particular comment about the documentaries produced by the Government Motion Picture and Advertising Studios by the leading British documentary-film maker, John Grierson, who visited New Zealand early in 1940. According to Grierson:

Over in England we seem to see and hear a lot about New Zealand but never anything about the human beings who live in it. I knew about your mountains and glaciers, your tree ferns and your sheep country. I knew a dozen times over from your films how butter was made and a dozen times over that it always seemed to be called 'Solid Sunshine'. I knew that you had a lot of Maoris who staged shows for rich tourists, and that you had mud that bubbled, and hot water on tap from out of the earth. I also knew that Taupo trout were the biggest in the world – but no-body had shown me so that I could remember it the face of a New Zealander. (quoted by Mirams, 1945: 204)

The logic of Mirams' other observation, that New Zealand was swamped by imported influences, also implied that the fundamental reason the Government film studios did not portray the social characteristics specific to New Zealand was because there were very few of any significance. After all, if our observations lead us to conclude that a society is dominated by imported influences, we do not expect its major distinguishing features to be original; such features are necessarily present in other countries because that is where they come from *mutatis mutandis*.

Without realizing it, however, Mirams stumbled upon a paradox. Mirams' first observation implies that as no other country was dominated to the extent New Zealand was by Australian, American and British culture, then this is what makes New Zealand really different (Australia, of course, was also dominated by the same three cultures but the Australian component in Australia was bigger than it was in New Zealand). Mirams' paradox, then, is that New Zealand's domination by Australian, British and American cultural stimuli has given it little chance of producing a strong autochthonous culture, yet the degree to which New Zealand was influenced by this particular combination of imported cultures was distinct. New Zealand exceptionalism hence was the product of a force that prevented distinct traditions from growing in the New Zealand soil.

This probably made New Zealand the most globalized society in the world since its popular culture came from the world's three most commercialized societies. The peculiarity was not lost on the expatriate novelist Dan Davin, who in an ironic aside in his war diary in 1941 observed that 'the world will fall to NZers and the people like them: the people who listen to commercial broadcasts [filled with Australian serials], go three times to *Gone with the Wind*, argue about football matches and talk about motor-car gears' (cited in Ovenden, 1996: 151).

But the New Zealand peculiarity has also been extraordinarily difficult to express in words and pictures. As artists, writers, composers and scholars

in other societies have no experience of the New Zealand pastiche, they have not developed conventions for articulating it, which means that New Zealanders have had to work out their own, and this is not an easy thing to do at all. It required extraordinary powers of imagination and observation to understand the New Zealand peculiarity and to invent an authentic style for telling stories about it, which in Morrieson's case was adapted from a most unlikely source – American pulp fiction.

Ever since the beginning of colonization, New Zealanders had believed that theirs was a unique society. As I have written elsewhere (1989), the Arcadian myth says that because New Zealand is a land of natural abundance, individual virtue is inevitably rewarded, the society needs minimal organization and is free from old-world evils and injustices, and the hard-working immigrant inevitably secures a home of his own by engaging in material progress in a rural setting. The myth still flourished when Mirams wrote his account of the cinema in New Zealand, though from the 1890s it now said that New Zealand's progressive state underpinned the productive and distributive functions of natural abundance.

The identity of New Zealand as the ideal society, however, had little social content apart from the state. A striking feature of books of photographic essays on New Zealand published before the 1940s is that, like the documentaries produced by government film makers, their symbols of New Zealand are the same as those expressed in countless literary descriptions of New Zealand ever since the mid-19th century. In all three genres the signifiers of the 'society' are not its social forms – in a minimally-organized society these are few and thin between the state and the family – but the material manifestations of the way of life which is both advanced and idyllic. The images focus on New Zealand's natural scenic wonders, New Zealand's natural abundance, the material rewards accruing to settlers (their homes), New Zealand's advanced technology (steam trains, steam ships), and New Zealand's multitudinous civilized amenities contained in New Zealand's splendid public buildings (e.g. Russell, 1919). The central belief in the prescriptive ideology – that what made New Zealand different came from it being God's Own Country – was necessarily represented by symbols denoting the physical and material and moral rather than the social.

Under these conditions, 20th-century New Zealand art, literature and social enquiry have rarely talked about anything that is significantly different about the society. The consequence is that they have left very little documentation on this matter, which in turn has prevented historians from putting a good case for exceptionalism. This is not to say that the art, literature and social enquiry have not been creative and have not told us anything of interest about New Zealand. On the contrary. But what is revealing to the historian is that the interesting things they have to say are – usually – unconscious adaptive responses to the elusive nature of the real distinctness. Although frequently ingenious and providing historians with masses of raw

data about New Zealanders, these adaptations nonetheless constitute evidence of the failure to solve the underlying problem: the problem of understanding and representing a major area of real distinctness (the New Zealand peculiarity) plus an imaginary area of distinctness (the Arcadian myth).

Certain New Zealand painters from the 1930s made a particularly innovative adaptation. Christopher Perkins and members of the Canterbury 'Group', like Doris Lusk, Rita Angus and Rata Lovell-Smith, invented a particular style that contradicted the Arcadian image of the idyllic landscape by emphasizing the harsh effects of the light and the stark effects of European occupation on it. But it was the stark effects they portrayed, not the people who made them, and the contrast with Australia is striking. Before the First World War, its painters (notably Tom Roberts and Frederick McCubbin) had already broken with the Arcadian tradition, depicting the Australian bush with its people in the style of the 'natural vision'; and from the 1940s, painters like Sidney Nolan and Russell Drysdale went further still, emphasizing the desolation of the bush and its crushed and desiccated human occupants. Interestingly, when from the late 1940s Eric Lee-Johnson and Russell Clark started to break the New Zealand painting tradition by giving central place to human figures in the landscape – a raw society interacting with raw nature – it was under the influence of Drysdale and Nolan (Robert McDougall Art Gallery, 1975: 12–14; Waikato Art Museum, 1981: 12; Johnstone, 2006: 24).

The contributors to the literary revolution of the 1930s and 1940s, on the face of it, rejected the Arcadian myth in its entirety. Instead of the ideal society, they saw a dystopia whose people were warped by Puritanism, hostile to aesthetics, alienated from the land, grossly materialistic, highly conformist, narrow, and, most of all, dominated by second-hand culture. Moreover, their rejection of the myth often led them to replace Arcadia's generic hero (the hard-working settler) with the rural itinerant. In addition, they developed a new prose style – the spare, plain, unsentimental speech of man alone – for telling their stories. Yet while the traits of dystopian New Zealand and man alone might have reflected something of New Zealand, they constituted adaptations of ideas borrowed from outside New Zealand. As several recent literary histories have pointed out, the models for man alone and the new prose style mainly came from the (mainly modernist) literature of other societies and thus were an intrinsic part of the second-hand culture the writers condemned (Jones, 2003; Murray, 1998). For instance, Mulgan's man alone and prose style were heavily influenced by Hemingway (O'Sullivan, 2003: 192); and though Sargeson based the speech patterns of his men alone on his own observations, there is some evidence that he borrowed the basic mould for his man alone characters from Henry Lawson (Sturm, 1988: 257–8). This is not to criticize the literary revolutionaries for adapting outside models but to say that, with the partial exception of Sargeson, the adaptations were forced upon them.

II

So far I have argued that the absence in the historiography of a good case for exceptionalism is a function of the largely invisible and inexpressible nature of key areas of distinctness which New Zealand in fact possessed. Having made this claim, I now want to anticipate an objection to it: namely, that I have overstated the relative importance in the pastiche of two of the three imported cultures, the Australian and American. The objection is understandable since it contradicts a long-standing myth – recently boosted and rejigged by James Belich in *Paradise Reforged* (2001) – that from the 1880s to the 1960s only one imported culture dominated New Zealand and that, of course, was British culture since New Zealand had such close relations with Britain. There is not enough space to examine this view by taking the entire history of European settlement in New Zealand. Hence the discussion is restricted to a shorter period, from the 1920s to the 1960s, when there has been less research on the Australian and American cultural influences and the ‘mother complex’ was supposedly in its heyday.

From the 1920s to the 1960s New Zealand was, to be sure, subjected to powerful anglicizing influences which impeded the development of autochthonous traits of a major kind. During this era a majority of New Zealanders were of recent British extraction, Britain continued to be New Zealand’s main source of permanent immigrants and imported books, New Zealand was economically dependent on Britain, New Zealand saw itself as the most loyal member of the Empire and Commonwealth and it was often described as more English than the English. Such things have been said many times before (e.g. Gibbons, 1992). But recognizing that a large amount of New Zealand culture was derived from Britain is one thing. The quantitative data suggests that the Australian and the American taken together were at least as important.

Mirams was correct in claiming that most imported movies came from Hollywood. Official data on both the value and length of imported films, compiled from 1914 onwards, show that in every year bar one (1915) the United States was the largest supplier by far, with Britain and Australia being a long way behind, in second and third place respectively.⁵ Given that New Zealand had 489 picture theatres by 1934 and that the average person went to the pictures once a fortnight by 1943, Hollywood must have been a big element in the pastiche (Mirams, 1945: 73; Dennis and Bieringa, 1996: 217).

Although it is commonly assumed that cultural contact with Australia diminished after federation in 1901 and practically died out from the early 1920s, being supplanted by the British,⁶ this is far from the case, which is to be expected perhaps, given that Australia remained New Zealand’s nearest neighbour. In many domains, especially those related to popular culture, Australian sources of influence not only continued to be important but may have grown in importance relative to the British. They are easily overlooked because they were generally mundane, ongoing, unconscious but nonetheless

surprisingly influential, making New Zealand an unwitting cultural outpost of its neighbour.

In 1921 the collection of New Zealand official statistics on overseas departures and arrivals was greatly improved, producing a good source of comparative information on the extent of New Zealand's links with other countries and the content of these links. The first thing here we should note are the data on the stated destinations of New Zealand residents temporarily visiting other countries, 1921–72: these show that Australia was consistently the most favoured destination by far, being preferred by an overall ratio of something like three to one over Britain. The purpose of these visits and duration are as yet unknown, but their overall cultural impact must have been considerable since on a per capita basis New Zealanders seem to have had a stronger travel bug than most people, more so, for example, than Australians up to the 1960s.⁷ Attention devoted to the expatriate New Zealanders in Britain has led us to overlook the many talented writers and artists who went to Australia for varying periods, seeking intellectual stimulation and superior exposure and work opportunities.⁸

Also highly suggestive are official data on arrivals in New Zealand according to the purpose of the visit and country of last permanent residence. From 1921 to 1972, with some minor changes, seven categories of purpose were specified.⁹ Although intending permanent immigrants consisted primarily or mainly of people from Britain in most years, Australian tourists, Australian business visitors, Australian officials and Australian sports-people, entertainers and theatrical performers outnumbered their British counterparts in each category by a ratio of roughly four to one or more on average.¹⁰

In addition to travel, the other conduit that poured a disproportionately large volume of Australian cultural influences into New Zealand was recorded music. Annual data on imports of this item (in terms of value) by country of origin were first enumerated in 1914. From then to 1981, Australia was the largest supplier in 27 of the 63 years for which official statistics were collected, the USA the largest in 11 of the 63, and the UK in 25.¹¹

Nor should we overlook the influence on New Zealand popular culture exerted by transplanted Australian media institutions. The most salient example is *New Zealand Truth*, which by 1928 had a circulation of 85,000 copies, an astonishing figure for the time. Established in 1905, its owner John Norton, the Australian newspaper magnate, deliberately modelled its sensationalist style on that followed by his chain of Australian weeklies of the same name. Kept under Australian ownership until 1949, its Australian-based directors not only exercised tight personal control over editorial policy, sacking any editor who dared to make it respectable, but recruited most of its many editors from Australia (Scholefield, 1958: 43; Joblin, 1990; Boddy and Mathews, 1991: 27–9).

New Zealand purchased more magazines, newspapers and comics from Australia than from any other country in most years from 1949 (when this broad category of imports by country of origin was first officially enumerated)

to 1981, except in 1951 and 1963–9, when the UK edged slightly into first place. The most popular of the Australian magazines would probably have been those most favoured by Australians themselves, including the *Bulletin* (1880), *Australian Women's Weekly* (1933), *Man* (1936) and *Pix* (1938).¹² Many Australian comics, notorious for their luridness and violence, were probably based on American models (Pearson, 1963: 104, 108–9, 115), but magazines like the *Women's Weekly*, *Man* and *Pix* were self-consciously Australian in much of their content.

This brings me to the last Australian import that washed over New Zealanders: commercialized radio entertainment. From the late 1930s to the 1970s Australia was the main overseas supplier; indeed for much of the period the Australian material may well have taken up more air time than all the New Zealand productions combined, including sports broadcasts. Serials made up the largest part of the Australian deluge: 206 were Australian made as opposed to nine British and 21 New Zealand.¹³ Sampling of a shorter period indicates that perhaps over one-quarter of total weekly air-time on commercial stations was devoted to Australian-produced serials alone. Although most of the story lines and scripts originally came from America, some of the most popular were in a genuinely Australian idiom, most notably 'Fred and Maggie Everybody' and 'Dad and Dave from Snake Gully', which was broadcast repeatedly, 2276 episodes each series, between 1937 and 1960.¹⁴

III

In the rest of this article, I want to outline an overarching explanation for the New Zealand peculiarity: its domination by Australian, British and American cultures. In so doing I will also demonstrate why New Zealand generally had little chance of developing major and distinct features of other kinds. The explanation is paradoxically a function of something exceptional about New Zealand's location in space.

The *Annales* historian, Fernand Braudel, created a conceptual schema that divides history into three levels of time: the '*longue durée*', the '*court durée*' and '*histoire événementielle*' (Braudel, 1972–3). According to Braudel, the first level has primacy over the other two and governs them. Indeed he employed the term '*histoire structurale*' to describe the effect of the natural environment: it *constrains* human possibilities on the other two levels. The notion of structure applied here is restricted to just one of the constituent parts of New Zealand's natural environment, namely, that it is more geographically isolated from the rest of the world than almost any other country that became a white settler society. This unusual degree of remoteness came from a combination of three circumstances. The first is that New Zealand has no land bridges to other countries. The second is that its global position – at between approximately 34 and 47 degrees latitude south and between

166 and 179 longitude east – means that it is tucked away deep in the south-west Pacific about 4480 kilometres due south of the equator, 1920 kilometres from south-eastern Australia, and separated by great distances from Asia, the Americas and Europe. Third is the relationship between its particular latitude and longitude, the global patterns of prevailing winds and ocean currents, and European overseas trade routes to Asia from the 17th to the early 19th century.

Although no-one else has applied Braudel's concept of structure to New Zealand history, there is nothing outlandish about using it to explain New Zealand culture. The effects of physical isolation on New Zealand culture have long been discussed (e.g. Curnow, 1960; Evans, 1990: 58–9; Lipson, 1948: 5, 496–8; Reeves, 1898: 413; Siegfried, 1914: 4–5, 10, 47–8; Sinclair, 1961). Physical isolation has been used by the global historian J. R. McNeill (2001) to explain long-term trends in both the ecological and the human history of Oceania, and to explain why the 'Magellan Exchange' took so long to take off after the (European) 'Indian Ocean Exchange' and the 'Atlantic Exchange'. The Australian historian Geoffrey Blainey (2001) also has produced an account of how Australia's physical remoteness from the rest of the world shaped major aspects of Australia's past. I will now apply the concept of structure, modified from Braudel, to pre-contact Maori, then to colonial Pakeha society and, lastly, to 20th-century New Zealand.

IV

New Zealand was at the end of the line for the first colonizers of the Pacific. According to the most reliable estimates, these Austronesian voyagers left their homeland in the New Guinea Archipelago in about 2000 BC and moved across the Pacific, mainly in a south-east arc, hopping from island to island, reaching the Marquesas in the eastern Pacific in about 300 AD. The reason they preferred the south-easterly trajectory was that it went into the face of the prevailing south-east trade winds and currents, thus enabling them to return home with the assistance of tail winds and currents if they ran into trouble (Irwin, 1992). Located deep in the south-west Pacific, New Zealand was the last place to be colonized: its discovery required travelling a relatively long distance in the least favoured and most hazardous direction, across and down wind. New Zealand's remote position thus dictated that the content of the parent culture of the Maori would be east Polynesian.

However, remoteness did not just dictate the source of the parent culture, it also delayed the settlement of New Zealand for an exceptionally long time (c. 1200 AD), ensuring that Maori had a shorter history than that of any other first people. The effect was to give Maori comparatively little chance of diverging radically from their parent culture. True, Maori fishing techniques, type of ornaments, use of bone, style of wood carving, forms of settled agriculture and beliefs appear to have been quite different from

those of the Polynesian eastern homeland. But the place of *mana* and *tapu* were as central in Maori culture as they were in the homeland, the Maori social organization was also based on distant kinship and the 'ramage' system, Maori placed as much emphasis on military prowess and warfare, and the language bore considerable similarity to that of the parent culture.¹⁵

In addition to limiting radical deviations, New Zealand's exceptional remoteness endowed Maori with a biota that was more vulnerable to human intervention than it was elsewhere and with a narrower range of domesticated plants and animals than that enjoyed by most Oceanic peoples.¹⁶ As a result, Maori possessed an unusually unstable relationship with their natural environment, and were hit by a subsistence crisis perhaps more quickly than most first peoples were. We need not go along with Tim Flannery's claim (1994) that at the point of European contact Maori society was on the verge of economic disaster, given the megafauna extinctions. But we can at least agree that from the inception of the crisis and right up to European contact, Maori were forced to be unusually adaptive, especially considering that unlike most other first peoples they could not relieve their demographic crisis through migration. The unusually acute adaptive pressures, it can be further argued, would have favoured the development of certain mental tools to a greater degree than elsewhere, selecting against rigid adherence to custom and selecting for pragmatism, a love of learning, resourcefulness, curiosity and so on. The development of these mental tools, and the resource constraints that stimulated their growth, explain one of the most striking aspects of Maori society from the point of early contact: their extraordinary receptivity to outside influences and willingness to adopt alien ideas and artefacts.

The early 19th-century story of the borrowing of Christian ideas, political forms, commerce, clothing, horse-racing, agricultural practices and so forth has been amply documented so I will not repeat it, except to say that in the 19th century it seems to have been stronger than that of indigenous societies with a more stable relationship with the pre-contact eco-system (Howe, 1977, 2003). Less attention has been given to their exceptional adaptability in the 20th century, but it seems to explain the remarkable speed with which they became consumers and producers of European popular culture and urbanized at a faster rate than any other indigenous people in the world (Gibson, 1973: 81–3). Therefore, although Maori are the most distinctive element in the New Zealand contribution to the pastiche, it is an element that does not radically differ from the other – Pakeha – elements.

V

It has become an orthodoxy in the study of new societies that the key to their histories is the specific places of origin of immigrants. To understand the new world, we must understand the regional and local cultures that immigrants brought with them. In my view the orthodoxy gives insufficient

weight to history. The most important influence on the content of a new society's founding ideas is not the social background of a pioneering group but the era when the pioneering group leaves.

In the case of Pakeha New Zealand, the founding ideas were those transplanted in the mid and late 19th century. Broadly speaking they can be called New Zealand's Australian and Victorian heritages. What predisposed – *but not determined* – these to be the founding ideas as opposed to other kinds of ideas was, at least in part, New Zealand's exceptionally remote geographical position compared with the locations of other white settler societies. The remoteness factor put New Zealand well off the beaten track, delaying its colonization as a white settler society for an unusually long period of time. The Americas, being far closer to Europe, were colonized by Europeans before any other part of the new world. Although European involvement in the Asian spice trade led the Indian Ocean to become the equivalent of the 'Atlantic Exchange' after the 16th century, there was little European movement into Oceania before the late 18th century. Oceania was far too remote from the main trade routes to Asia that went from west to east around the Cape of Good Hope then followed the Roaring Forties before heading north; navigators were deterred from entering Oceania's vastness until they devised reliable and convenient means for measuring longitude in the 1760s; and access to Oceania from Cape Horn was greatly impeded by the strength of the prevailing westerly winds (between latitude 40 and 60 degrees south). By 1787 only one European ship is known to have landed on Australia's eastern coast (Blainey, 2001: 18, 183–4; McNeill, 2001: 312–14).¹⁷

Inevitably, Australia was colonized decades before New Zealand and more quickly mainly because it was closer to Asia and partly because it was closer and more accessible to Europe given the Roaring Forties. Hence, whereas Australia's population of Europeans was 70,000 by 1830 (including 7000 freemen), New Zealand's was just 2000 when Britain abolished transportation to New South Wales in 1840. After it became a penal settlement in 1788, New South Wales was bound to take a relatively serious strategic interest in New Zealand at some point. But that was delayed for about three decades, initially by the penal colony's initial struggle for survival, and subsequently by New Zealand's location. Tucked away to the south and east of Australia, New Zealand was too remote to provide ports of call for Australia's commerce with Asia, which along with convictism dominated its economy up to the 1820s (Blainey, 2001: chs 2–4).

It would be absurd to say that New Zealand's relative remoteness determined the precise year at which it was annexed: 1840 was the end point of a series of contingent events. Even so, we should remember that the period of the 1830s and 1840s created a *conjoncture* highly favourable to annexation at some point during these decades, namely, the peaking in Britain of the political influence of the powerful humanitarian movement with its

view that the Crown must intervene to protect Maori from 'fatal impact' with Europeans. New Zealand's relative remoteness did not produce this *conjoncture*. Rather, what remoteness did was to defer British overseas expansion in the direction of New Zealand until the historical moment when the *conjoncture* was developing out of the late 18th-century evangelical revival.

Given that remoteness predisposed New Zealand to be colonized by Britain at a certain point in British history, it follows that the pioneers transplanted certain historically-specific ideas to New Zealand – the Australian and Victorian heritages – as opposed to others. Thus New Zealand was not the recipient of other kinds of historically-specific cultural heritages that were transplanted to other new societies which, being less remote from an expanding Europe, were established at earlier stages. It is for this reason that New Zealand did not have a slavery heritage (unlike the United States), an *Ancien Regime* heritage (unlike Argentina, Chile and Uruguay), a Dutch heritage (in contrast to South Africa), a French heritage (in contradistinction to Canada) or a convict heritage (as opposed to Australia). Although New Zealand possessed an Irish Catholic heritage, it was much weaker than in the United States and Australia. New Zealand received a substantially smaller share of the Irish diaspora than they did, partly because its exceptional remoteness made it more expensive and more difficult to travel to; but the remoteness factor also ensured that, by the time the 1847 famine triggered the main diaspora, European settlement of New Zealand had barely started. As much more was known about Australia and America and because it had far fewer settlers capable of generating chain migration, New Zealand was much less able to attract Irish immigrants.¹⁸

New Zealand's 'Australian heritage' has seldom been called by that name but we can apply it to the heterogeneous cultural fragments that were transplanted to New Zealand from Australia over the 19th century (Sinclair, 1988). Not surprisingly, New Zealand's greater remoteness ensured that more ideas and practices crossed the Tasman from Australia than went the other way. New Zealand was eastern Australia's frontier up to the 1860s, and having the advantage of an earlier start, Australia's European population was more than three times larger than New Zealand's, and its economy was correspondingly bigger at any given point from 1840 to 1900. More specifically, the biggest cultural influence that Australia perhaps exercised over New Zealand as a result of its earlier start consisted of the mores carried by its pastoral workers and miners to New Zealand, the principal source of New Zealand egalitarianism (Goodman, 1988: 32–5; Olssen, 1988).¹⁹ This would never have happened unless Australia and New Zealand had been settled at the times they were, for the timing of Australia's foundation dictated it would have a radical fragment at that point (according to Hartz), and the foundation of New Zealand some 40 years later allowed it to go through the experiences of pastoralism and mining that drew the biggest carriers of Australian popular radicalism to New Zealand.

New Zealand's Victorian heritage has yet to be studied in depth. But I would suggest its main strands consisted of high intellectual culture (associated with figures like Darwin and Mill); a passion for voluntary organization; a body of common sense notions (concerning, for example, respectability, gender divisions, material progress, the home, the dangers of the city, self-help, mutual aid, race); and explicit adaptations of these common sense notions to the new land (adaptations that composed the Arcadian myth). As these Victorian values and beliefs were introduced into an ideological vacuum, Darwinism met with less resistance in New Zealand than anywhere in the world (Stenhouse, 1999).

Let me now return to my central questions: why did Pakeha society have such a limited chance of developing autochthonous elements of a major nature, and why was it dominated by the three imported cultures of Britain, America and Australia? The answers to these questions are many, but the most important are the structural effects of New Zealand's exceptional physical remoteness. One such effect was to make Pakeha history exceptionally short. As in the Maori case, but to a much greater degree, Pakeha settlement occurred very late in historical time relative to the standards of new societies. Its shorter history in turn gave Pakeha society less chance than other settler societies to evolve autochthonous features in place of – and in addition to – those embodied in the founding culture(s) imported from the parent society.²⁰ To put this in another way, New Zealand's much shorter history meant that it had a much weaker probability of experiencing the sorts of events and states of affairs that allow a country's history to take a unique course.

Another structural effect of New Zealand's exceptional remoteness was to delay European settlement to a crucial point in development in world history, namely the revolution in transport and communication, consisting of a multitude of innovations. Amongst these were a series of technological improvements in the motive power of ships and in the reorganization of shipping routes that slashed travelling time from New Zealand to Europe from about four months in the 1840s to about six or seven weeks by 1914; the linking of New Zealand with Europe by the electric telegraph in 1876; the rise of the movies from the 1890s; the advent of radio telegraphy in 1908; the establishment of radio broadcasting from the 1920s; and the introduction of television in 1960 (Robinson, 1964; Day, 1994; Wilson, 1994; Watson, 1996). The revolution strongly exposed New Zealand – Pakeha and Maori alike – to external cultural influences. As a result, New Zealanders consumed with avidity and alacrity the latest metropolitan cultural trends, high and low.

Certainly the cultures of other societies were also profoundly affected by the revolution in transport and communication. But there is good reason to believe that New Zealand's exceptional physical remoteness made it more susceptible to metropolitan cultural influences than perhaps any other society. The crucial connection here is through the relatively tiny size of the

population. Although tight government controls over immigration from 1920 were partly responsible for minimizing New Zealand's population size, there were two bigger factors. One was that New Zealand's exceptionally short history obviously gave its population a much smaller chance to reach a given size through natural increase than had European occupation been as long as that of, say, America or Australia. Another factor was that New Zealand's exceptional distance from Europe greatly restricted its capacity to compete with other new societies for immigrants from 1815 to 1914 when its base population was being established and the greatest transoceanic migration flows in world history were taking place. As the distance to New Zealand from the old world was longer than that for any other settler society, the journey to New Zealand and its cost were correspondingly greater. In addition, as other new societies were settled earlier than New Zealand, intending immigrants knew more about them and were more likely to have support networks in them. To some degree, Australia's population size in the 19th century was also constrained by distance, but what more than off-set this disadvantage was that the Imperial Government transported more than 160,000 involuntary immigrants to Australia, making its foundation population base many times larger than it otherwise would have been (Blainey, 2001: 151–4).

The unusually low level of New Zealand's population had far-reaching consequences for its cultural pattern. For one thing, a very small population pool has a correspondingly low probability of throwing up those rare great figures of history who in other societies have made their history exceptional – charismatic leaders, creative geniuses and extremely gifted business entrepreneurs. As well, the very shortness of New Zealand's history eliminated the possibility that the extraordinary innovators as well as the appropriate conditions would both emerge at the same time.

As New Zealand's population was much smaller than that of other settler societies, it also had a correspondingly lower capacity to support a wide range of highly specialized and *professional* producers of popular and high culture. Just as the small population has been the biggest constraint on the industrialization of New Zealand (Blyth, 1974), so it has been the greatest constraint on the formation of a high division of cultural labour unless the state intervened.

At the same time, however, the intense exposure of New Zealand consumers to the lifestyles of the three metropolitan societies cultivated their tastes and whetted their appetites for all the cultural goods that could not be made internally. To satisfy the consumer demand that local producers could not supply, New Zealand had to import an exceptionally large proportion of its cultural goods. It became, that is to say, an import dependent culture – one that imported more of its cultural goods than it made itself. The rather notorious reputation of New Zealand for exporting its talent is an indirect effect of remoteness in reducing employment opportunities for specialist

producers of popular and high culture. The other indirect effect has been the conspicuous failure of the expatriates to return. In an economy where remoteness has created low employment opportunities for talented specialists but high demand for their products, it is more cost effective to import the goods of the talented than to employ them internally.

VI

The physical isolation of a country or region is frequently associated with cultural lag, backwardness, cultural insularity and, at its most extreme, radical divergences. But with New Zealand the opposite was true. The circumstances producing its exceptionally remote geographical position made its history of human occupation much shorter than it was for other countries, giving its people far less chance to evolve major traditions of their own, and predisposing them to be unusually heavy borrowers of other cultures.

Paradoxically, therefore, what made New Zealand distinct is the abnormal degree to which its people have borrowed from other cultures and the particular combination of cultures they have borrowed from. However, we have not understood how this particular area of distinctness might make a good case for New Zealand exceptionalism, for quite naturally we associate national distinctness with autochthony, not with the factors that have prevented it.

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Notes

1. Apart from the Treaty of Waitangi, which was not peculiar to New Zealand, other possible candidates include the pioneering of female suffrage; unusually high rates of house and land ownership until the mid-20th century; the failure to produce a fascist movement; and that the Labor Party was the first mainstream socialist party in the western world to abandon nationalization as its overarching objective.
2. The five turning points were 1890, 1908–12, 1935, 1949–51 and 1984. American ideologies held sway in all these bar 1935 when Douglas Credit dominated.
3. Informative commentaries are Simpson (1982) and Millen (1996).
4. One Australian critic of Morrieson's novels (McLaren cited in Millen, 1996: 188) observed that 'New Zealanders judged from this sample seem to share the attitudes of Australians in general to such things as hypocrisy, scabs, the police, booze, women and gambling. There is similar conflict between city and country

and a similar feeling that the respectable middle class miss out somewhere along the line. On the other hand there is a more matter-of-fact and human understanding of the Maoris than any Australian writer has shown to the Aborigines and an almost poetic feeling for the land'. What McLaren might also have noted is that the 'man alone' figure of NZ myth was anticipated 40 years earlier by the Australians, though it must be emphasized that 'man alone' figures do not feature in Morrieson.

5. Data compiled from tabulations in the annual *New Zealand Statistics: Trade and Shipping*, 1921–48, *External Trade*, 1949–60, and *Imports*, 1961–81; although the official categories change over time, they do not alter my generalization above.
6. This is certainly the assumption made by Belich (2001: 52, 440ff).
7. I have based this in part on a comparison between New Zealand and Australia in terms of their respective rates of temporary departures of permanent residents at certain benchmark years: 1929, 1936, 1951, 1961, 1966, 1971. The NZ rate exceeded the Australian (by about two-fold) up to and including 1966. Australian data from the *Official Yearbook of the Commonwealth of Australia*.
8. The writers include Jane Mander, R. A. K. Mason, Robin Hyde, Greville Texidor, Douglas Stewart, Jean Delvanny, Eve Langley, Louis Johnson, Ruth Park, William Hart-Smith, Carl Stead and Monte Holcroft. See Sturm (1988: 256) and the appropriate entries in *Dictionary of New Zealand Biography*, URL: <http://www.dnzb.govt.nz/>. The painters include Adele Younghusband, Robert Johnson and Cedric Savage; see relevant sections in Johnstone (2006). Weaver Hawkins and Godfrey Miller are other examples I have come across in the Art Gallery of New South Wales.
9. Departures data from *Population Statistics*, 1921; *Population and Dwellings*, 1922–37; thereafter, *Population, Migration and Building Statistics*.
10. Arrivals data from *Population Statistics*, 1921; *Population and Dwellings*, 1922–37; thereafter, *Population, Migration and Building Statistics*. Detailed notes on NZ official statistical sources and my treatment of them can be seen in the original and longer version of this article (Fairburn, 2006).
11. *New Zealand Statistics: Trade and Shipping*, 1921–48; *External Trade*, 1949–60; and *Imports*, 1961–81. Calculations based on assessed monetary value.
12. *New Zealand Statistics*. Australian data from Greenop (1947: 119, 256–62). Also Sturm (1988: 248–50).
13. Radio New Zealand Archives, Christchurch.
14. See also Sturm (1988: 249–50). Data from Radio New Zealand Sound Archives, and the electronic data base, Screensound.
15. From Davidson (1987), though she also stresses the geographical diversity of pre-contact culture.
16. From the discussion in Diamond (1998: chs 8–9), we can infer that Maori had only one of the world's dozen main edible plant species (the sweet potato), none of the major five domesticatable animal species, and none of the minor nine animal species.
17. A further factor in discouraging European penetration of Oceania, as opposed to Asia, was that the eastern spice trade had existed for centuries before European contact. Thus, in contrast to Oceania, European traders were able to tap into the eastern trade without the expense and inconvenience of setting up from scratch an entire infrastructure for the processing, storage, etc. of

tropical goods which they would have needed to do in order to establish an Oceanic trade.

18. NSW had a subsidized immigration scheme in the 1840s that attracted a disproportionately large Irish population about two decades before substantial government-assisted immigration schemes were introduced in NZ.
19. Australian historians have much debated the origins of popular radicalism, as Goodman (1988) indicates.
20. The concept of settler society is from Denoon (1983).

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